

Thomas Sesler

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Hi Vital team,

I applied to Vital last fall and didn't make the cut. Fair enough - you've said yourselves only about 5% get the call. But I promised myself I'd circle back when I had more to show, and this Visual Designer role is the one worth coming back for, especially the "AI as a creative tool, not afraid of it" line.

Here's what's changed since November. I completed two project-based externships this spring (News Corp, on AI features for digital news products, and TikTok/Sapphire, on brand and content strategy), and I've kept shipping client work. The clearest look at how I work is Andy's Pub (andyspub.com): I designed and built the entire site, shot and edited the food photography myself, and gave the owner a custom back end with Claude built into it - at the start of each month he just uploads his menu and specials, the AI parses them onto the site, and the daily specials rotate automatically from there. No developer, no manual updates. I take a brand from Figma to a deployed, responsive site using an AI-assisted build workflow, and I leave clients with something they can actually run themselves. (Another, a local bar, is now over 2,000 visitors a month.)

That back end points to the niche I'm building right now: productizing local businesses' catalogs - menus, product lists, inventories - into structured, self-managed web content designed to actually get found, in regular search and in the AI answer engines you write about. For a small shop, that local visibility is the whole game, and it's the problem I want to keep solving - a big part of why Vital's the place I keep circling back to. The site I'm finishing now, for an aquatics retailer, is built around exactly that idea.

I've worked across hospitality, retail, and my own software, so the range you described is the part I'd look forward to, not the part that intimidates me - and a marketing degree from UNH means "design exists to drive results" is just how I think.

But here's the honest reason I want this. I've spent the last couple years mostly working alone: freelancing, cold-pitching businesses around town, shipping everything end-to-end. I can work hard and I can deliver on my own. What I've figured out is that solo is also my ceiling - I'll only grow so far without other designers around me to critique the work, push it, and stay a few steps ahead. That's what an agency gives you, and it's what I'm actually after. Vital's the one I'd most want it from, and it's in the part of the world I'm moving back to anyway.

So the logistics are easy: I went to school in New Hampshire and I'm heading back to the seacoast to be near the friends and community I built there. I'm in Erie, PA at the moment and the move's happening regardless - and I'll be up in the area July 4-10, so if you'd like to meet in person, I can come into the office then. Portsmouth works for me long-term, and I'm looking in the \$60-70k range, flexible for the right fit.

Portfolio's at straydesign.co. Thanks for the second read, and for writing a job post that sounds like actual humans wrote it.

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P.S. - Even if I'm not the right fit for the role, I'd love to stay on your radar. Andy's Pub (andyspub.com) is the two-minute version of how I work. And Sea Cave, an aquatics retailer with a much deeper

catalog, goes live any day - once it's up I'd be glad to send it your way; it's the clearest example yet of the catalog-and-visibility work I described.